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'COMED FOUR' CASE

Court reverses convictions

Grants new trials for Pramaggiore and McClain and orders them released from prison on bond

By Jason Meisner
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Just hours after hearing arguments, a Chicago federal appeals court on Tuesday announced it will grant new trials to former ComEd CEO Anne Pramaggiore and lobbyist Michael McClain and ordered them released from prison on bond.

The extraordinary development came nearly three years after Pramaggiore and McClain were convicted as part of the landmark "ComEd Four" case alleging

a conspiracy to bribe then-House Speaker Michael Madigan.

"Both Pramaggiore and McClain are entitled to release," the order from the 7th Circuit U.S. Court of Appeals said. "The United States must make arrangements to release Pramaggiore and McClain from federal custody forthwith."

The appeals court said a written opinion on the order for a new trial will be filed at a later date. It's unclear whether the U.S. attorney's office would go forward with the case, given the new legal landscape



Pramaggiore



McClain

and the age of the defendants.

A spokesperson for the U.S. attorney's office had no immediate comment.

In an emailed statement, Pramaggiore's spokesperson, Mark Herr, thanked the 7th Circuit for its swift decision to order her release

pending the written opinion.

"It has never made sense that Ms. Pramaggiore has served a single day in prison, much less the three months she has served — for 'crimes' the Supreme Court said did not exist," Herr said.

Joel Bertocchi, McClain's lead appellate attorney, told the Tribune: "We are pleased by the court's order and look forward to receiving the court's opinion."

In accordance with the ruling, U.S. District Judge Manish Shah late Tuesday afternoon ordered McClain and Pramaggiore released under the same bond conditions set when they were first charged in November 2020. The paper-

work would likely take a day or so to process.

The rapid-fire decision came after consolidated arguments for McClain and Pramaggiore before the 7th Circuit, Tuesday. The three-judge panel had tough questions for a government lawyer about how the conspiracy conviction could stand after the high court said "gratuities" given to elected officials with no direct tie to official actions are not illegal.

After that ruling, a district court judge threw out underlying bribery convictions in the "ComEd Four" case but left intact the main conspir-

See **COURT** on Page A6An American Airlines jet taxis past a United Airlines jet at O'Hare International Airport on Tuesday in Chicago. **JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Long-shot American-United merger could reshape O'Hare

Antitrust expert says flying would become more unpleasant and expensive for Chicagoans

By Talia Soglin
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

A long-shot megamerger between United and American airlines could reshape O'Hare International Airport and make flying more expensive and unpleasant for Chicagoans, aviation and antitrust experts told the Tribune.

United CEO Scott Kirby floated the idea of such a merger — which would create the largest airline in the world — to President Donald Trump earlier this year, Bloomberg and Reuters reported.

An airline industry megamerger

is still a big "if," experts cautioned. It isn't clear if any formal merger proposal process is underway. And any merger proposal involving the two massive airlines would likely face an uphill battle when it comes to passing muster with federal regulators.

But O'Hare — where the rival airlines both have hubs and together control about 80% of the airport's gates — could be an epicenter for impact if a merger did ultimately get the green light.

Chicago-based United and Texas-based American have for months engaged in a knock-down, drag-out fight over market share at

the airport, adding so many flights out of Chicago that federal regulators have warned the airport lacks the capacity to keep up. A merger between the two airlines would cool that competition and could make air travel more expensive, experts said.

Spokespeople for both United and American declined to comment. The Chicago Department of Aviation, which runs O'Hare, also declined to weigh in.

Consumer advocates are typically highly skeptical of corporate consolidation, wary of reduced competition leading to higher prices and fewer options for

consumers.

And airlines compete against each other not just on the basis of cost, but also on the quality of the service they offer, said Jim Speta, an antitrust law expert and professor of law at Northwestern University.

For instance, airlines compete on offerings like leg room and flight frequency, he said.

"So we might see changes in that regard between the airlines, where they're not competing as hard to provide comfortable seats," Speta said. "Or they're not

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Diplomats pursue new round of talks

US blockade of ports in Iran forces most tankers to turn back

By Munir Ahmed
and Sam Metz
ASSOCIATED PRESS

ISLAMABAD — Diplomats worked through back channels Tuesday to arrange a new round of talks between the United States and Iran after Washington enacted its blockade of Iranian ports, while Tehran threatened to retaliate by striking targets across the war-weary region.

President Donald Trump said a second round of talks could happen "over the next two days," telling the New York Post the negotiations could be held again in the capital of Pakistan.

United Nations Secretary-General Antonio Guterres concurred, saying it's "highly probable" that talks will restart. He cited a meeting he had with Pakistan's deputy prime minister, Ishaq Dar.

An initial round of talks aimed at permanently ending the U.S.-Iran conflict failed to produce an agreement last weekend. The White House said Iran's nuclear ambitions were a central sticking point.

The New York Times, citing people familiar with the talks, reported Monday evening that the U.S. proposed a 20-year suspension of nuclear activity. That could allow the Iranians to claim they had not

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INSIDE

NFL wants update on stadium project

The NFL's stadium committee has called for a meeting with the Bears during the week of April 27, according to a league source, to get an update on the status of the team's bid for a new home. **Sports**

Bold pastries and a cheeky 'sandweesh'

Seedo's Levantine Bakery makes Palestinian, French and American-influenced pastries bold yet familiar, plus a cheeky manakish-inspired "sandweesh." **Review in Food & Health**

Tax frustrations

The late Jeff MacNelly's editorial cartoon lampooning the IRS is perhaps the most popular single cartoon in Tribune history. We re-run it this tax day in honor of its 50th anniversary. **Page A9**

Chicago Theological Seminary stops admitting new students

170-year-old institution facing mounting financial woes

By Rebecca Johnson
and Kate Armanini
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

The Chicago Theological Seminary has stopped admitting new students in its degree programs amid mounting financial woes at the 170-year-old institution that participated in the abolitionist movement and the Underground Railroad prior to the Civil War and where civil rights icon the Rev. Jesse Jackson once attended.

Brad Braxton, the school's president, told the Tribune in a state-

ment Tuesday that the seminary decided to cease admissions while it undergoes a "board-approved strategic planning process" that is focused on ensuring the school is able to continue its mission for "generations to come."

"CTS has prepared bold, justice-minded leaders for public service, grounded in progressive approaches to theology and ethics," he said. "That calling has never been more urgent, and our commitment to it has never been stronger."

He also said the seminary remains committed to ensuring that currently enrolled students have a "clear, supported path" to

See **SEMINARY** on Page A4Bicyclists pass the Chicago Theological Seminary on the campus of the University of Chicago on Tuesday. **JOSH BOLAND/TRIBUNE**

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